



■ Backing-up Girls

To motivate meritorious rural girls to pursue higher education, Madhya Pradesh government has launched a unique scheme christened Gaon Ki Beti.

living in scattered habitations sans educational facility.

In yet another major initiative, the state government has linked its Ladali Laxmi Yojana to education of girls. Under the scheme a certain amount is deposited in the Post Office in the name of a newborn girl, which would increase to Rs. 1 lakh 18 thousand till she grows to be 21 year old. When she passes V examination she is given a sum of Rs. two thousand and on getting through VIII Rs. four thousand. A sum of Rs. would be given to her on clearing X examination and Rs. 200 per month as scholarship on passing XI and XII examinations. With this, the parents would not consider the education of their daughters a burden.

■ Pratibha Kiran Yojana

In a bid to provide opportunities of higher education to the intelligent girls of Below Poverty Line (BPL) families in urban areas, Madhya Pradesh government has started 'Pratibha Kiran Yojana.' Under this scheme, higher education would be provided to girls who secure a minimum first division in higher secondary class from urban-based government schools and would receive scholarship worth Rs. 7500 per annum.

Last year 821 students were provided with this scheme. A total of Rs. 24,63,500 worth of scholarship was provided last year. This year the government has made a provision of Rs. 61 lacs for the scholarships.

■ Potential for a Higher Education Hub

Action is being taken to set up a Special Education Zone (S.Ed.Z) in the



Under this, girls of all villages passing the higher secondary examination in first division are awarded a scholarship of Rs. 500 per month to pursue higher education. This year the number of beneficiary girls is likely to cross 15 thousand for which a provision of Rs. 9 crore 52 lakh has been made.

In order to provide means to get to the school in other villages, the government decided to provide bi-cycles free of cost to such girls who have passed the VIII and got admission in IX in a school in some other village. A total of 2 lakh 16 thousand bi-cycles are being distributed this year. In last three years about one lakh 90 thousand girls have already been provided this facility.

In addition to this, free textbooks are being distributed to about 80 lakh 18 thousand girls studying in I to VIII. In 280 educationally backward development blocks free uniforms are distributed to girls in government schools under National Programme of Education for Girls at Elementary Level (NPEGEL). In remaining 33 blocks the state government distributes uniforms from its own resources. This year 55 lakh girls are being given uniforms.

Girls who drop out mid way from middle schools are motivated to continue their education through open school and their fee is reimbursed under girls education programme. Besides, 1084 residential Bridge Courses are being conducted for over aged girls in rural areas to prepare them to get admission in classes in accordance with their age. This year, 3768 non-residential Bridge Courses are being started from October 2. Apart from this, residential arrangement is being made with 185 middle schools for girls of families

form of Knowledge City at Bhopal for which 635 acre of land has already been allotted by the government. The Knowledge City would house reputed medical, engineering and other colleges on a single premises for which they would be given concessions.

The Private University Act has been brought to facilitate establishment of private universities by internationally renowned and reputed educational institutions in the state. This would also enable the institutions to offer courses in tune with the requirements created by industrialization and globalization.

To safeguard the interests of students, a fees regulatory committee has been constituted by enacting a law. This would strike a balance between the interests of the students and the institutions. Madhya Pradesh is one of the few states to have set up fees regulatory committee by enacting a law as per the directive of the Supreme Court.

With a view to associating the students with college management and to educate them on democracy, the direct elections to the students unions of colleges were held simultaneously in all the colleges after a long gap of 20 years.

The achievements during the last four years augur well for the future of Madhya Pradesh. It can, thus, be justifiably claimed that successfully facing the challenges Madhya Pradesh is fast moving towards becoming a high education hub.